offences. No country can function well if every person is allowed to lay a separate rail network or to have their own definition of murder.

In order to make decisions on such collective matters, a countrywide public conversation must first be held, following which the people's representatives – elected in free and fair elections – make a choice. But even after that choice has been made, it should remain open to re-examination and correction. While the network cannot change its previous choices, it can elect a different government next time.

MAJORITY DICTATORSHIP

The definition of democracy as a distributed information network with strong self-correcting mechanisms stands in sharp contrast to a common misconception that equates democracy only with elections. Elections are a central part of the democratic tool kit, but they are not democracy. In the absence of additional self-correcting mechanisms, elections can easily be rigged. Even if the elections are completely free and fair, by itself this too doesn't guarantee democracy. For democracy is not the same thing as majority dictatorship.

Suppose that in a free and fair election 51 per cent of voters choose a government that subsequently sends 1 per cent of voters to be exterminated in death camps, because they belong to some hated religious minority. Is this democratic? Clearly it is not. The problem isn't that genocide demands a special majority of more than 51 per cent. It's not that if the government gets the backing of 60 per cent, 75 per cent, or even 99 per cent of voters, then its death camps finally become democratic. A democracy is not a system in which a majority of any size can decide to exterminate unpopular minorities; it is a system in which there are clear limits on the power of the centre.

Suppose 51 per cent of voters choose a government that then takes away the voting rights of the other 49 per cent of voters, or perhaps of just 1 per cent of them. Is that democratic? Again the answer is no, and it has nothing to do with the numbers. Disenfranchising political rivals dismantles one of the vital self-correcting mechanisms of democratic networks. Elections are a mechanism for the network to say, 'We made a mistake; let's try